

The Coastal California Garden Year

A MONTH-BY-MONTH QUICK REFERENCE · ZONES 9B & 10A

Our seasons run backwards from the seed-packet chart. Mild, wet winters and cool, foggy summers make fall the second spring and give you something to plant in every single month. Keep this page by your planner and match the month to the move.

January **BARE-ROOT SEASON**

Plant bare-root fruit trees, cane berries, rhubarb, asparagus, and artichokes. Sow peas, fava, spinach, and lettuce. Prune dormant deciduous fruit trees.

March **TRANSITION**

Direct sow carrots, beets, greens, and potatoes. Keep warm-season seedlings growing indoors. Feed the garlic and onions planted last fall.

May **PLANT OUT**

Set out tomatoes, peppers, squash, cucumbers, and basil once fog-nights ease. Direct sow beans, corn, and summer squash. Mulch everything.

July **LOOK AHEAD**

Peak harvest. Start fall broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage, and kale indoors now. Sow heat-tolerant lettuce in shade. Water deeply and consistently.

September **THE BIG MONTH**

Sow peas, spinach, lettuce, and cilantro. Transplant broccoli, cauliflower, and cabbage. Last call for carrots before days shorten.

November **NATIVES IN**

Keep planting garlic and onions. Sow fava and peas. As the rains return, plant California natives and shrubs. Clean up spent beds.

February **START INDOORS**

Start tomatoes, peppers, and eggplant under lights. Direct sow carrots, beets, radishes, chard, and more peas. Last call for bare-root.

April **WARM-UP**

Harden off tomatoes and peppers for a late-April coastal set-out. Direct sow beans; start squash and cucumbers indoors. Watch for aphids.

June **SUCCESSION**

Sow another round of beans, squash, and cucumbers. Keep planting basil. Harvest the first summer crops and side-dress heavy feeders.

August **SECOND SPRING**

The fall door opens: direct sow lettuce, carrots, beets, kale, and spinach. Transplant brassicas. Set out strawberry plants for spring fruit.

October **GARLIC MONTH**

Plant garlic and onions, the best moves of the month. Sow peas, spinach, and one more lettuce. Transplant lettuce and cabbage early.

December **REST & PLAN**

Bare-root season reopens: order fruit trees and berries. Plant natives in the rain. Sow fava. Apply dormant spray. Plan next year in your planner.

Three rules that hold all year here

1. Plant fall crops on time. A week late past Labor Day costs real growth that never comes back.
2. Never plant summer crops early. Warm afternoons fool people; short days do not.
3. When the rains come, plant natives and bare-root. Winter is our planting season, not our off-season.

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